

still seemed to be in good form, going by what I had read and heard about them.

I unwittingly appeared to have touched a raw nerve.

GB did not respond immediately. He seemed to think over it, then said: ‘You must have heard the Gujarati saying that if a dog walks under a moving bullock cart, you may get the impression that the dog is carrying the cart on its back. But that is an illusion. It is the bullocks who are doing the heavy work.’

‘I don’t get it,’ I said, though I had a vague idea of what he was trying to get at.

‘What I meant to say is that it is the promoter and the employees who are doing all the hard work. Just because you identify a good company to invest in, it does not make you great. The so-called legendary investor or fund manager owes his fortune to the management and the hard work of the employees. Why do you all glorify the investors so much?’ GB ranted.

‘But that is too extreme a view, Govindbhai. Having worked with some of the best people in the industry, I am sure you know that identifying good companies is hard work. If it was all about luck there would have been many more wealthy people in the market. And your experience will tell you that those who relied solely on luck have not lasted long,’ I countered.

‘Maybe . . . let us talk of something else, Lala. How are your investments shaping up?’

A few days later I met up with Monk and told him about my conversation with GB.

Monk laughed.

‘Maybe one of his big-ticket clients shafted him. Or maybe he is disillusioned with life in general and the market in particular. Or maybe he recently read Taleb’s *Fooled by Randomness* (a book in which Taleb argues that winning in financial markets is about chance and not skill). But don’t worry; knowing him, GB will soon get over this mood. Meet him a month later and you might hear him hold forth on the stock market’s contribution to the economy,’ Monk said.

We chatted for a while, and Monk ordered *bhel* from the same place he had at our first meeting in his office years ago.

‘Almost feels like going back in time,’ I told Monk.

‘Thankfully, some things never change, like this *bhelwallah* and his stuff. He has put up half a dozen stalls in Bandra and Khar, but the stall across the